Northwest Arkansas Times, Fayetteville, 14 July 2002

Sparing the rod

Fayetteville drops corporal punishment from policy, becomes second school district in county to do so

By Jenn Long
Northwest Arkansas Times

A recent Fayetteville School Board decision to remove an age-old disciplinary procedure from its policy books marks the district as the second in Washington County to say farewell to paddling.

Winslow School District, the smallest district in the county, banned corporal punishment five years ago.

Despite an increasing national trend to banish corporal punishment from school discipline policies, other Washington County school district officials said they doubt they will follow Fayetteville's example in the near future.

During their June meeting Fayetteville school board members unanimously approved a motion to purge the corporal punishment procedure from the student handbook with little discussion.

"The district has adopted a discipline with dignity approach and I think it is obvious that corporal punishment is not a part of the discipline with dignity philosophy," Fayetteville Superintendent Bobby New said.

For Fayetteville schools, the move to scratch out corporal punishment was an attempt to bring the policy up to date with actual school practices.

Paddling, though previously sanctioned by Fayetteville's districtwide policy, has not been actively in use for several years, officials said.

Fayetteville school administrators were prompted to make the recommendation after a parent voiced some concerns over the punishment's inclusion into the discipline policy, New said.

"It was in policy, but not in practice," he said. "I think that parent's concern was symbolic of the community and the community philosophy and we are glad as a school district to respond to that concern."

All school districts that do use the punishment policy regularly do so only as a last resort, as stated in their district policies, and the procedure seems to be reserved for younger grades.

As in Farmington, Elkins High School and middle school principals do not use corporal punishment, while the elementary school administrators will use it sparingly.

Keeping students in school is what prompts many school officials to take up the paddle rather than suspend students, where they essentially get a vacation from school. Paddling can effectively punish students and still keep them in the classroom.

Revising current corporal punishment policies isn't completely out of the question, local superintendents said, especially those policies that haven't been reviewed in years. However, removing the paddling punishment altogether is highly unlikely.

Farmington School District's procedure hasn't been reviewed since 1986, which is why there has been some discussion among school administrators to revisit the policy.

"I think it may be time to revisit, not that we would do away with the policy," Wright said. "I think it would be good to go back and look at the policy and determine if there is a need to revise it."

Copyright ©1997- 2001 Community Publishers, Inc./ Arkansas-Democrat Gazette. All Rights Reserved.